WHAT THE WATER KEEPS

Reference adaptation for testing

(test kit - opening and final sequences)

Based on the novella by M. L. Osorio

24 September 2026
Scenes 9-35 are outlined in the answer key, not written here.

1 INT. MINISTRY DRAWING OFFICE - CITY - DAY 1

A Ministry survey sheet, flat on a drafting table. Contour lines. Parcel numbers. In the lower corner, a single ruled line of blue ink and the words PROJECTED WATER LEVEL 412 M.

A woman's finger traces the blue line the length of the valley.

INES (V.O.)
My father said a map is a promise.

The printed valley becomes the real one: the same shape, suddenly green.

2 EXT. BRIDGE AT VELL BAIXO - DAY 2

APRIL 1957.

A country bus pulls away in its own dust. Left behind on the bridge: a theodolite in a wooden case, a levelling staff, two tripods, a case of drawing instruments, and one small suitcase.

INES MARO (29) stands among them like luggage at a station. She looks up the valley. Green. Much greener than paper.

Across the road, the door of the POST OFFICE opens. ODILE FARRE (60s, grey cardigan, arms folded) comes out and looks at the tripods.

ODILE
You'll be the surveyor.

INES
Ines Maro. From the Ministry.

ODILE
Odile Farre. Postmistress. I also keep the telephone, the register of deaths, and the key to the church. So if you want anything in this valley that isn't a sheep, you'll be wanting me.

Odile looks at the theodolite. Then at Ines.

ODILE (CONT'D)
They said a surveyor. They didn't say a girl.

INES
I'm twenty-nine.

ODILE
That's what I said.

Odile picks up the levelling staff and shoulders it.

INES
I can carry that.

ODILE
Not in Vell you can't.

3 EXT. VILLAGE LANE - CONTINUOUS 3

Odile climbs, staff on her shoulder. Ines follows with the theodolite case hugged to her chest.

Ahead, a TRUCK is being loaded outside a farmhouse: chairs, a mattress, a birdcage. A FAMILY works in silence.

ODILE
Gates close the end of September. Forty-three families have signed. Thirty-one are arguing about the money. Sixteen haven't answered the letters.

INES
And the rest?

ODILE
One. He burned his.

A TELEPHONE rings inside the post office behind them. Odile doesn't turn.

ODILE (CONT'D)
Tomas Aurelio. Keeps bees at the narrows. He'll not sign. His grandmother's grandmother is under the church floor. You'll want his land and he'll not let you, and I'm telling you now so you'll not say no one told you.

4 INT. INN - TOP ROOM - NIGHT 4

A narrow room. One window up the valley.

The suitcase is unpacked: three dresses, a hairbrush. Done.

The instruments take the rest of the night. Ines cleans the theodolite part by part on a cloth, the way someone cleans a thing they love.

Last from the suitcase: a folded sheet, soft with age. She opens it.

A hand-drawn floor plan of a small apartment, scale 1:20, every chair drawn in. A child's bed exactly the length of the kitchen table. In the hallway, a tiny inked X, labelled in a man's hand: WHERE INES LOST THE TOOTH.

She pins it above the bed.

5 EXT. RIVER VELL - THE NARROWS - DAY 5

The valley pinches. A flat FERRY hangs on a rope across the river.

On the far bank, rows of white HIVES stand in a slope of wild thyme like a small, orderly town. Among them, a veiled figure moves slowly.

Ines waits on the near bank with her tripod.

A long time.

The figure comes down to the water and lifts the veil. TOMAS AURELIO (35). The face of a man who has been told many things by officials and believed none of them.

TOMAS
The Ministry.

INES
I need the height of your land above the river. For the compensation.

TOMAS
I know what for.

INES
Two days. I won't disturb the hives.

TOMAS
You'll disturb them by being here. They know when something's being counted.

He tugs the ferry rope once, idly. The boat knocks the bank.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
And when you've measured it?

INES
I draw it. The Ministry sets the compensation from the drawing.

TOMAS
And then they drown it.

INES
Yes.

This surprises him. He looks at her properly.

TOMAS
At least you don't lie. The last one lied. He said the lake would be beautiful.

INES
It probably will be.

TOMAS
So is a grave, if you keep it tidy.

He goes back up among the hives.

6 EXT. THYME HILL - DAWN 6

Ines drives survey stakes into the far bank's slope. Each has a strip of red cloth.

She takes a small pot of BLUE PAINT from her bag. One stake, the one level with the Ministry line, gets a band of blue.

The blue stake stands halfway up the slope, just below the cottage door.

7 EXT. THE NARROWS - FERRY - NEXT DAWN 7

Ines arrives at the ferry with her tripod.

On the deck of the ferry: her stakes, pulled up, stacked in a neat pile. On top of them, a jar of HONEY.

She looks up the slope. No one.

8 MONTAGE - STAKES AND HONEY 8

- Ines drives the stakes in again. The blue one last.

- Dawn: the stakes on the ferry deck. Two jars of honey.

- Ines drives them in again, harder.

- Dawn: the stakes on the deck. Three jars.

9 EXT. THE NARROWS - DAY 9

No stakes today. Ines sits on the bank with three jars of honey in a row beside her, and waits.

Tomas comes down. Stops at a distance.

INES
I can make the survey without your land. I'll estimate it from this side. Estimates run low. You'll be paid for land ten metres lower than it is.

TOMAS
Then they'll have paid me less to drown more.

INES
Yes.

TOMAS
You're a strange sort of Ministry.

INES
I'm a surveyor. The Ministry's in the city.

He sits on the bank, a little way off. Looks at the water.

TOMAS
Two days.
(beat)
And you'll write down the names.

INES
What names?

TOMAS
Of the fields. Everything here has a name. Your map has numbers.

He stands.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
You want my land, you take the names with it.

He goes. Ines looks at her field book. On the page: PARCEL 212. She writes beneath it, small: NAME?

SCENES 10-35: SEE REFERENCE OUTLINE IN THE ANSWER KEY

36 INT. INN - TOP ROOM - DAWN 36

SEPTEMBER.

Out of the window: the lower valley is a lake. Grey, flat, full of the tops of trees. The bridge is gone. The mill is gone.

Up the far slope, a thin grey line of chimney smoke rises from Tomas's cottage. The blue stake below his door is under water.

Ines is dressed, packed, sitting on the bed. Her suitcase at her feet.

Outside, a TRUCK HORN. Twice.

She doesn't move.

The horn again. Then the truck's engine, leaving.

She watches the smoke.

37 INT. INN - FRONT ROOM - LATER 37

Chairs stacked on tables. The register of deaths sits on the bar beside Odile's handbag. Odile has moved in.

Odile joins Ines at the window. They watch the smoke together.

ODILE
He's moved his bees. Up to the high pasture, on the Dog. Took him three nights. Carried every hive himself.

INES
Then he's leaving.

ODILE
He's moved his bees. He hasn't moved himself.

She lets that sit.

ODILE (CONT'D)
He went up to the church yesterday with blankets.
(beat)
His grandmother's grandmother is under that floor. I told you that the day you came.

INES
I know.

ODILE
You'll not say no one told you.

38 INT. MINISTRY ARCHIVE - CITY - NIGHT 38

Rows of flat steel drawers. One lamp.

Ines alone at a slanted table with a sheet of linen, a ruling pen, a bottle of black ink. Her lips move silently as she works. Her body hides the sheet. What she is writing stays hers.

39 EXT. THE LAKE - DUSK 39

The inn's rowing boat, low in still water. Ines rows alone over the drowned valley.

Beneath the hull, just visible through the water: a stone wall. The top of a gate. A drowned field.

She steers without looking round. She has measured every metre of it.

The CHURCH stands up out of the lake on its rise like a ship. The door is under. Only the tower and the roof ridge are dry.

She ties the boat to a window grille of the tower and climbs in.

40 INT. CHURCH TOWER - TOP - NIGHT 40

Lamplight. The BELL, enormous, green-black, the crack in its lip.

Tomas sits against the wall beside it. A blanket. A lamp. A jar of honey. He is not surprised.

TOMAS
Go back. It's rising a metre a day.

INES
I know. I measured it.

TOMAS
Then you know how long I have.

INES
Six days to this floor. Eight to the bell.

She sits on the top step. Where she sat in April.

INES (CONT'D)
I brought you something.

She slides an oilcloth tube from her coat. Unrolls it on the stone between them. Weighs the corners down with the lamp, the honey jar, her two hands.

Linen. The engineer's stamp: VALLEY OF VELL - SISTERS RESERVOIR - ARCHIVE COPY.

And beside every parcel number, in black ink, in small careful capitals: THE WIDOW'S PIECE. ANSELMO'S EYE. LITTLE LISBON. THYME HILL. THE DOG.

Tomas stares at it.

INES (CONT'D)
They took the names off. In the drawing office. So I put them back. At night. I told the archivist I'd found an error in the contours.
(touching the linen)
This is the copy they keep. Forever. Nobody will ever look at it again. But it will be there.

TOMAS
Why?

INES
A map is a promise. That the place will still be there when you come back.
(beat)
Even if it isn't. My father told me that.

He looks up at the bell.

TOMAS
And the bell?

INES
Your grandmother didn't know who it belonged to. Maybe it doesn't belong to anyone. Maybe it just rings.

A long moment.

TOMAS
You went in for the box. In April.
I thought you were a fool.

INES
I was.

TOMAS
So am I.

He rolls up the map.

41 EXT. THE LAKE - NIGHT 41

The boat moves away from the tower. The lamp in the bow. The water so still the church stands in it twice, once upward, once down.

Tomas rows. Ines faces back toward the tower.

Silence. Oars. Nothing else.

Then: one long, flat, cracked note from the tower. It rolls up the valley and comes back.

Not a leaf moves. No wind at all.

Tomas stops rowing. They sit in the drifting boat and listen until there is nothing left to listen to.

42 EXT. LAKESHORE - NEW WATERLINE - DAY 42

The last Ministry TRUCK waits, engine running. Ines's suitcase and instruments are loaded.

Tomas stands with her at the edge of the new lake. Above them on the slope: the hives, moved to the Dog. Beside them, a new stone hut.

He gives her a jar of honey. She gives him the working map: pencil, coffee rings, every name.

TOMAS
Come back.

INES
There's nothing to come back to.

TOMAS
There's the Dog. And the thyme.
(beat)
And the names.

She gets into the truck. It pulls away along the new shore.

In the water below the road, the top of a blue-painted stake, just breaking the surface.

43 INT. INES'S OFFICE - CITY - DAY 43

SUPER: JUNE.

A drafting table under a window. A MESSENGER sets down a small parcel. No letter.

Ines opens it: a jar of honey. She opens the jar. Smells it. Thyme.

On the shelf behind her: four more empty jars, lined up.

44 EXT. OLD QUARTER - CITY - WINTER NIGHT 44

YEARS LATER.

Ines, older, walks home through a crowded street.

A church bell rings once from somewhere she can't see: one long flat note, a little cracked. It goes up the street and comes back.

She stops. People flow around her. She stands until there is nothing left to listen to.

45 INT. INES'S APARTMENT - NIGHT 45

A clean sheet of paper. A ruling pen. Beside the drafting table, pinned to the wall, a child's floor plan at 1:20.

Ines draws the first contour of a valley.

FADE OUT.